

D.K.T.E. Society's Textile and Engineering Institute, Ichalkaranji

(An Autonomous Institute, Affiliated to Shivaji University, Kolhapur)

Accredited with 'A+' Grade by NAAC



Promoting Excellence in
Teaching, Learning & Research

**Department of Computer Science and Engineering
(Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning) 2026-2027.**

**THE COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT PROJECT REPORT ON
“DIGITAL EMPOWERMENT”**

Under the guidance of: Prof. Rekha Kamble

Developed By:

- | | |
|-----------------------|----------|
| 1. Madhur Bhandari | 25UAM116 |
| 2. Harshvardhan Patil | 25UAM113 |
| 3. Shreyas More | 25UAM071 |
| 4. Siddharth Bhosale | 25UAM072 |

CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that,

1. Madhur Bhandari 25UAM116
2. Harshvardhan Patil 25UAM113
3. Shreyas More 25UAM071
4. Siddharth Bhosale 25UAM072

Have successfully completed the project work, entitled
“DIGITAL EMPOWERMENT”

In partial fulfilment for the award of degree of Bachelor of Technology in Computer Science and Engineering (Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning). This is record of their work carried out during academic year 2026-27.

Date: 24/09/2026

Place: Ichalkaranji

Prof. Rekha Kamble
[Project Guide]

Prof. Dr. S.K.Shirgave
[Head of Department]

DECLARATION

We the undersigned students of S.Y.C.S.E.(AIML) declare that the Community Engagement Project work report entitled “DIGITAL EMPOWERMENT” written and submitted under the guidance of Prof. Rekha Kamble is our original work. The empirical findings in this report are based on the data collected by us. The matter assimilated in this report is not reproduction from any readymade report .

1. Madhur Bhandari	25UAM116
2. Harshvardhan Patil	25UAM113
3. Shreyas More	25UAM071
4. Siddharth Bhosale	25UAM072

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INDEX

CONTENTS	PAGE
1. Introduction	5
2. Problem Statement	6
3. Problem Description	7
4. Facilities Requirement Related to Problems	8
5. Field Visit	9
6. Technical Solutions	14
7. Conclusion	16
8. References	17
9. Letter	18

1. INTRODUCTION

Digital technology has become an essential part of everyday life. Today, people use smartphones for communication, education, banking, shopping, entertainment, and accessing government services. Although digital services have become common, many people living in rural areas still face difficulties in using them safely and effectively because of limited awareness.

Our project, "Digital Empowerment: A Study on Digital Literacy, Cyber Security, Artificial Intelligence Awareness, Fake News, and Financial Literacy," was carried out through an offline awareness program in a village. Instead of conducting online sessions, our team personally visited the village, interacted with the residents, and explained important digital concepts in simple language.

During the visit, we observed that many villagers owned smartphones but were not fully aware of cyber security, digital payment safety, fake news, Artificial Intelligence, or government digital services. Most of them used mobile phones mainly for calling, WhatsApp, YouTube, and social media.

To improve their understanding, we conducted face-to-face discussions and awareness sessions. We explained how to use digital technology safely, how to identify fake news, how to protect themselves from cyber fraud, and how Artificial Intelligence is becoming a part of daily life.

This project helped us understand the real challenges faced by rural communities. It also improved our communication skills, teamwork, planning ability, and social responsibility while contributing to digital awareness in society.

2. PROBLEM STATEMENT

Technology is growing rapidly, but digital awareness among many rural people is still limited. Although smartphones and internet facilities are available, many villagers do not know how to use digital services safely.

The major problems identified during our study are:

- Limited knowledge of digital literacy.
- Lack of awareness about cyber security.
- Very little understanding of Artificial Intelligence.
- Forwarding fake news without verification.
- Unsafe digital payment practices.
- Dependence on others for online services.

Because of these problems, villagers are more likely to become victims of cyber fraud, misinformation, and financial scams. Therefore, there is a need to conduct offline awareness programs to improve digital knowledge and promote safe use of technology.

3. PROBLEM DESCRIPTION

During our interaction with villagers, we identified several issues related to digital awareness.

Digital Literacy: Many villagers use smartphones only for making calls, watching videos, or sending WhatsApp messages. They are unaware of several useful digital services such as DigiLocker, online government services, digital health applications, and educational resources.

Cyber Security: Many people did not know the importance of keeping passwords secure or protecting their personal information. Some villagers shared that they had received suspicious phone calls asking for bank details or OTPs. They were unaware that sharing such information could lead to financial fraud.

Artificial Intelligence Awareness: Most villagers had never heard about Artificial Intelligence. After explaining AI with examples such as Google Maps, voice assistants, language translation, and smart farming, they understood that AI is already being used in many applications they use daily.

Fake News: Many villagers forward messages received on WhatsApp without checking whether the information is true. Some believed fake health advice and misleading government-related messages. We explained the importance of verifying information before sharing it with others.

Financial Literacy: Although several villagers use digital payment applications, many do not understand safe payment practices. Some were unaware of QR code scams, fake payment requests, or the importance of protecting their UPI PIN.

Overall, we found that lack of awareness, rather than lack of technology, was the main challenge.

4. FACILITIES REQUIREMENT RELATED TO PROBLEMS

To conduct the awareness program successfully, the following facilities and resources were required.

Human Resources:

- Project Guide
- Student Team Members
- Village Sarpanch
- Local Residents

Materials Used:

- Smartphones
- Notebook and Pen
- Camera for Documentation

Other Requirements:

- Permission from village authorities
- Open space
- Cooperation from villagers
- Proper planning and teamwork

These facilities helped us conduct the awareness program smoothly and effectively.

5. FIELD VISIT

As part of the Community Engagement Project, our team visited Ichalkaranji Village to understand the level of digital awareness among the villagers.

After receiving permission from the village authorities, we met the residents and introduced the purpose of our visit. We interacted with people of different age groups, including students, farmers, shopkeepers, women, and senior citizens.

Initially, we asked simple questions about smartphone usage, online payments, cyber security, fake news, and Artificial Intelligence. Their responses helped us understand their level of awareness.

After the discussion, we conducted an awareness session covering the following topics:

- Importance of digital literacy
- Safe use of smartphones
- Cyber security precautions
- Protection against online fraud
- Importance of strong passwords
- Safe UPI and digital payment practices
- Identifying fake news before forwarding
- Introduction to Artificial Intelligence with simple examples

We explained these topics in easy language using examples from daily life so that everyone could understand.

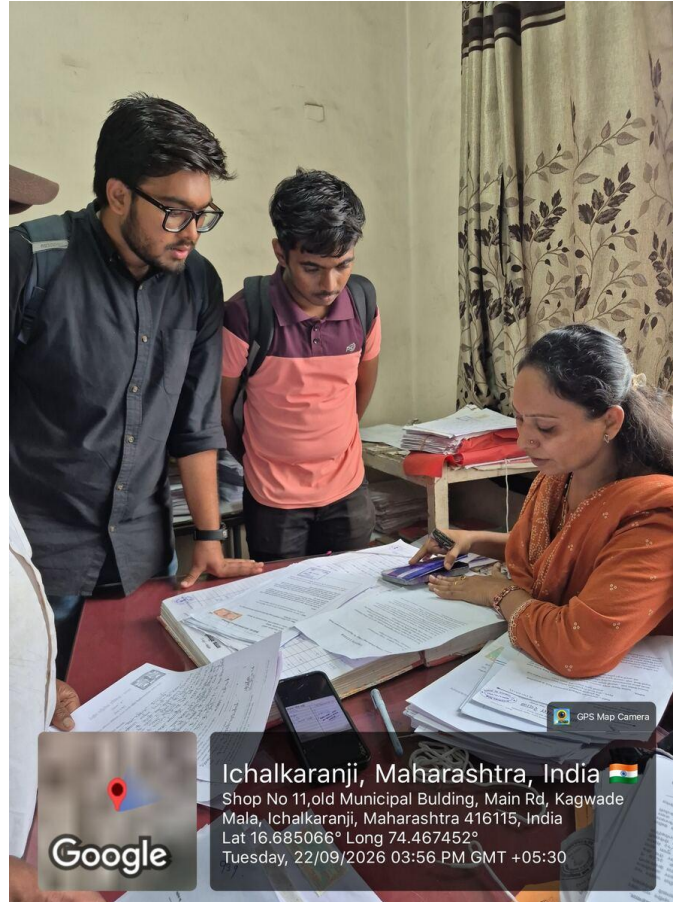
The villagers actively participated in the session and asked questions related to online banking, OTP fraud, mobile applications, and fake messages. We answered their questions and cleared many common misconceptions.

At the end of the visit, we encouraged everyone to share the knowledge with their family members and neighbours. The villagers appreciated our efforts and expressed interest in participating in similar awareness programs in the future.

The field visit gave us practical experience in understanding community needs and communicating technical concepts in a simple and effective way.

Photographs of the Field Visit









6. TECHNICAL SOLUTIONS

Based on our observations during the field visit, we suggest the following solutions.

Digital Literacy:

- Conduct regular digital awareness programs.
- Teach villagers how to use government digital services.
- Encourage learning through practical demonstrations.

Cyber Security:

- Never share OTP, passwords, or UPI PIN.
- Use strong passwords.
- Enable two-factor authentication wherever possible.
- Avoid clicking unknown links.

Artificial Intelligence Awareness:

- Explain AI through practical examples.
- Demonstrate useful AI applications in education, agriculture, healthcare, and communication.
- Encourage responsible use of AI tools.

Fake News:

- Verify information before forwarding.
- Check official government websites and trusted news sources.
- Avoid spreading rumours or unverified messages.

Financial Literacy:

- Promote safe digital payment practices.
- Verify QR codes before making payments.
- Regularly update banking applications.
- Report suspicious activities immediately to the bank or cyber crime authorities.

These solutions can improve digital awareness and help villagers use technology safely and confidently.

7. CONCLUSION

The Digital Empowerment project was a valuable learning experience for our team. Through our offline village visit, we understood the real challenges faced by rural communities regarding digital technology.

We observed that although many villagers own smartphones, they still require proper guidance on digital literacy, cyber security, Artificial Intelligence, fake news, and financial literacy. Our awareness session helped them understand these topics in a simple and practical manner.

The interaction with villagers also improved our communication skills, teamwork, confidence, and understanding of community engagement. This project showed us that spreading digital awareness through direct interaction can create a positive impact on society.

We believe that regular awareness programs in villages will help people use digital technology safely, reduce cyber fraud, and encourage responsible digital practices.

8. REFERENCES

1. Digital India Mission.
2. Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY).
3. National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal.
4. Reserve Bank of India – Digital Payment Awareness.
5. NCERT Digital Literacy Resources.
6. Artificial Intelligence awareness materials.
7. Guidance provided by the Project Guide.

9. LETTER

VISITING LETTER

Subject: Visiting Ichalkaranji Village for Digital Empowerment Study

To,
The Concerned Authority / Village Administration
Ichalkaranji Village, District Kolhapur

We are students of D.K.T.E and Engineering Institute, and we are visiting Ichalkaranji Village, District Kolhapur, as part of our academic project on "Digital Empowerment". The purpose of this visit is to understand the level of digital awareness and literacy among the villagers and to study the practical challenges they face while using digital services and technologies.

As part of this project, we intend to interact with villagers and collect information related to digital literacy, cyber security, Artificial Intelligence (AI) awareness, identification and prevention of fake news, and financial literacy. The interaction will help us understand existing awareness, common difficulties, and the need for responsible and safe use of digital technologies.

The visit will be conducted only for educational and academic purposes. We will maintain respectful communication with the residents and use the information collected only for our project work. We kindly request the concerned authority to permit and support our visit to Ichalkaranji Village.

We sincerely appreciate your cooperation and support in helping us complete this academic project successfully.


लिपीक (आवक - जावक)
अपर तहसिलदार कार्यालय
इचलकरंजी
22/9/2020